OUR RUSSIAN ARMS

The international sanctions on Russia following its invasion of Ukraine could have an impact on ongoing defence deals with India, including for the Triumf S-400 missile platform and the $375 million joint venture with the DRDO to export BrahMos missiles to the Philippines. The Indian armed forces are highly dependent on Russian military hardware.

INDUCTED KIT



ARMY

Russian T-72 and T-90 battle tanks are the mainstay of the Indian Army's armoured strength



AIR FORCE

Of the 667 aircraft in the IAF's ground attack fleet, over 70 per cent are of Russian origin. All six air-refuelling flying tankers with India are Russian-made Ilyushin-78s.



NAVY

The INS *Vikramaditya* is a refurbished Russian Kiev-class carrier, and many of the aircraft it carries–like MiG-29Ks–are of Russian origin. The fleet also includes four guided-missile destroyers, six frigates, one nuclear-powered submarine and eight diesel-powered submarines of Russian origin.

denied access to SWIFT, India's trade will be affected. Simultaneously, the rise in international oil prices—they breached the $100 a barrel mark and touched $116 within a week of the invasion—threaten to fuel inflationary trends, bringing pain to the economy and the common man (see accompanying report, *How India will be Hit*).

So, even as the US and Europe pressured India to support condemnatory statements against Russia in the UN Security Council, India chose to tread the middle path. It abstained from voting on the resolutions, but put out an explanatory note that was fairly critical of Russia. India stated that it valued the territorial integrity and sovereignty of all states, stood for respecting international law and believed in diplomacy and dialogue, calling for an immediate cessation of all hostilities. "We are essentially telling Russia that we don't like what you are doing but we will not vote against you," Raghavan says, "which is alright." A senior MEA official adds, "We need to keep our lines of communication open with all parties concerned, take care of our interests wherever they are, including in terms of the equities we have. If we commit ourselves either way, we will not be able to do so. We also can't afford to burn our bridges." Varma puts it bluntly: "Once we commit ourselves to either side, it will be like issuing a blank cheque they would cash on with no guarantee to take care of our concerns."

THE CHINA SHADOW

Ironically, India found itself on the same side as China in the UNSC, as Beijing too abstained from voting. In 2008, China had not come out in open support of Russia's military action in Georgia, nor has it recognised its 2014 annexation of Crimea so far. But then the world's two most powerful autocrats—Putin and Chinese president Xi Jinping—signed a far-reaching agreement on February 7, just two weeks before the Russian invasion. The 5,000-word joint communique, covering a whole range of issues, stated: 'Friendship between the two states has no limits. There are no forbidden areas of cooperation.' It brought the two countries closer than ever before, while clearly challenging NATO's role in international security, and questioning the US' dominance as a global power and the liberal world order.

Having China firmly on his side emboldened Putin to